

Two days, four releases, and **one thing** **that needs you.**

Everything that was built, fixed and found while you were away — written for a five-minute read, with the technical detail kept out of your way.

PREPARED FOR	FROM	PERIOD	STATUS
Philip N. Tete	Favour Nwachukwu	1–2 October 2026	Draft for your review

4	6,383	18	1
releases shipped and committed	lines of new code across 69 files	verification standards received from Vanessa	live issue waiting on a 2-minute fix

READ THIS BIT IF YOU READ NOTHING ELSE

Contractors cannot currently save their bank details on the live site. We know exactly why, the repair is written and tested, and it has not been applied yet. It takes one person a couple of minutes. Everything else in this report can wait; that cannot.

In one minute

Three sentences, if you are between meetings.

We built the money rails. Contractors can now give us their payment details once, we check them, and each project has one named contractor who receives the stage payments. This was the biggest gap between "Groundwork tracks a build" and "Groundwork pays for a build".

We solved the half-built project problem. When a partner contractor brings a client whose house is already at roof level, we no longer have to pretend the project starts at stage one. The earlier stages are recorded honestly as completed outside Groundwork, and the client is billed only for what is left.

We found a real mistake and fixed it properly. Some database changes reached the live system before they had been reviewed. The review then found genuine problems. That mismatch is what broke the contractor payment form, and the repair is written, tested four different ways, and waiting to be applied.

THE HONEST HEADLINE

Groundwork can now *record* and *approve* a payment to a contractor end to end. It still cannot *send* one, because no payment provider is connected yet. That is the single biggest thing standing between us and a live paying project — and it is why the Cauridor recommendation in section 4 matters.

What shipped

Four releases went out on 2 October. Here is each one in plain terms, and why it mattered enough to build.

✓ Contractors can be paid directly

A contractor now enters their mobile money number or bank account once, on their own page. It is reused on every project they work on. An administrator must check the details before any money can be approved against them.

Why it matters: before this, there was nowhere in Groundwork to put a contractor's account. The details lived in somebody's phone. Now they live in the system, checked, and attached to the person rather than the job.

✓ Each project has one contractor who gets paid

You name a main contractor on the project. Stage payments go to that person. The system will not let you name someone who has not accepted the job, or who has no Groundwork account — because there would be nowhere to send the money.

Why it matters: a project can have several contractors. Without this, "who gets this stage payment?" had no answer the system could give.

✓ We stopped throwing away the contractor's phone number

Contractors give us their phone number on the application form — a nine-section form. When they were approved and created an account, that number was simply dropped. It now carries across automatically.

Why it matters: every approved contractor was unreachable on WhatsApp through the platform, despite having told us their number weeks earlier. We were asking people for information we already had.

✓ **The WhatsApp button now reaches the right person**

It used to message the client, only. It now offers the client, the project's contractor, or a verifier. Where a project has two verifiers — a civil engineer and an electrical engineer, say — it asks you which one rather than guessing.

Why it matters: "message whichever verifier the system happened to pick first" is how confidential project detail reaches the wrong professional.

✓ **Projects can join half-built**

This is the one you raised in the 30 September stand-up. A partner brings a client whose house is already at the roof. Groundwork now records the earlier stages as *completed outside Groundwork* — no payment due, no verification required, and critically **no Groundwork certificate**, because we did not watch that work. The client is billed for the remaining stages only.

Why it matters: the alternative was asking a client to fund and have verified a foundation that was poured in 2019. All ten stages still show on the tracker, as you asked, so the record and the audit trail stay complete.

✓ **A stage reader that understands a contractor's own words**

A contractor types "the roof is on, starting the wiring" and the system proposes the right stage, showing which words it matched so an administrator can disagree. If the wording is ambiguous — "foundation is complete, roofing materials are ordered" — it refuses to guess and asks a human to choose.

Why it matters: partner contractors do not know our ten stages. Guessing wrong either skips verification on real unbuilt work, or bills a client twice for a floor they already paid for.

✓ **Vanessa's verification standards arrived**

Eighteen documents — foundation, structural, electrical, plumbing, roofing, painting, land, soil, borehole, energy supply, site tools, MEP and final inspection — are now stored in the project rather than in email.

Why it matters: these are the raw material for the verification engine. Until now the checkpoint design was being built from meeting notes.

What this looks like on screen

You have an administrator account. These are live screens from it — real data, no mock-ups.

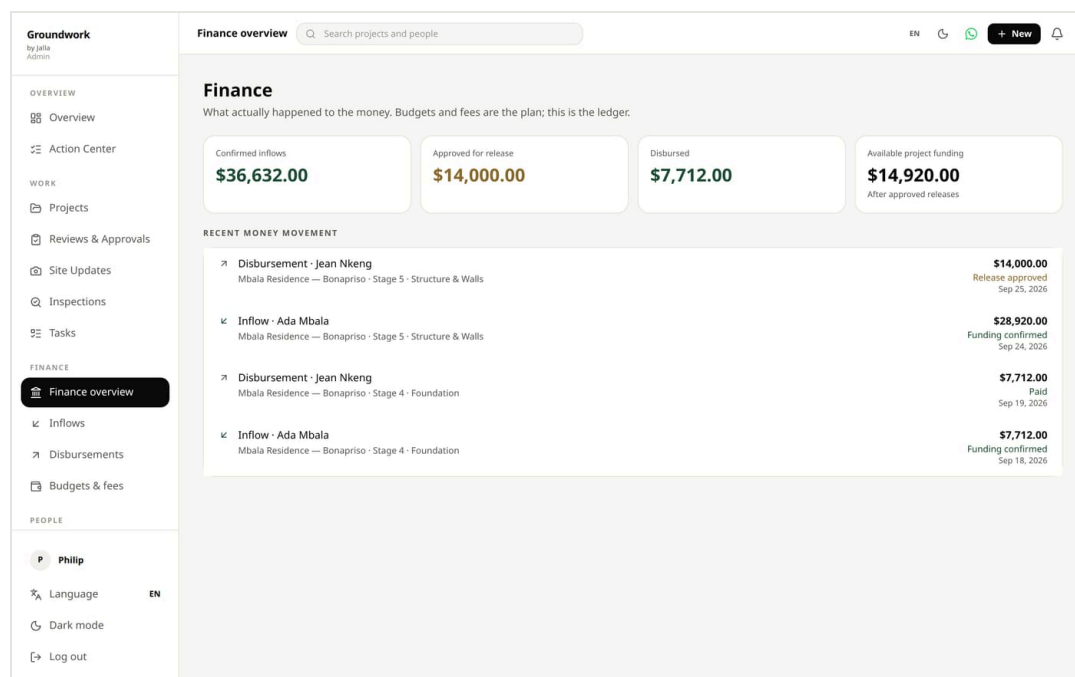


FIG. 1 Finance overview. Four figures that answer "where is the money". Everything here is a real ledger entry — there are no estimated or illustrative numbers anywhere in Finance, by design. "Available project funding" is what remains after releases that have already been approved.

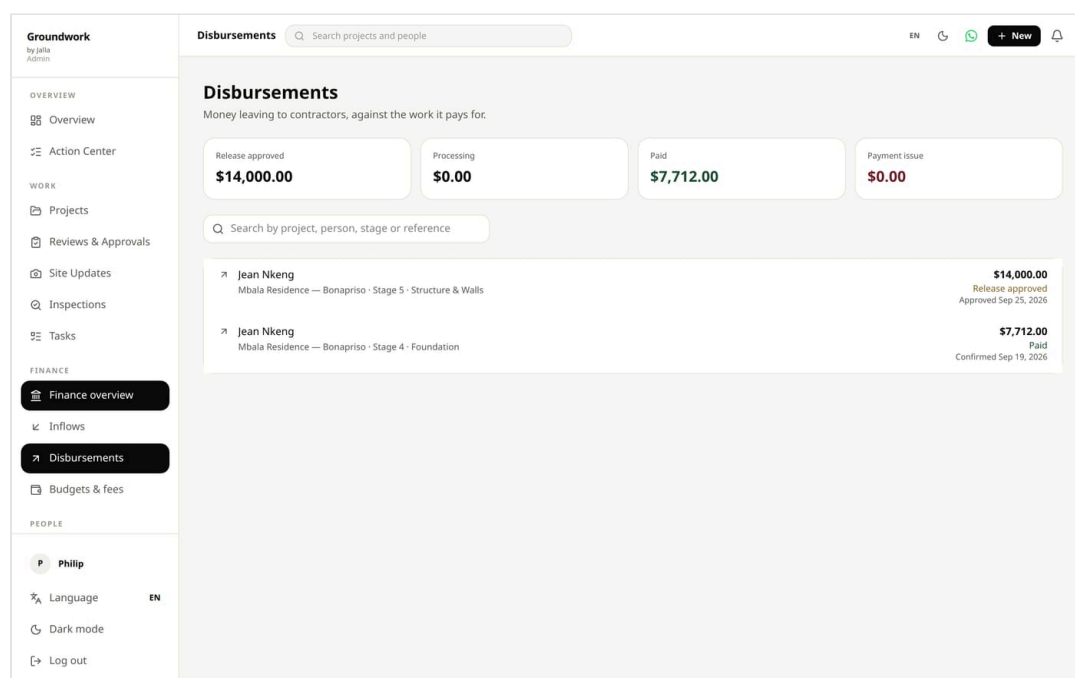


FIG. 2 Disbursements. Note *Processing \$0.00*. That is not an empty state — it is the honest consequence of having no payment provider connected. Money can be approved for release and recorded as paid when confirmed by hand, but nothing is in flight with a provider, because there is nothing to be in flight with.

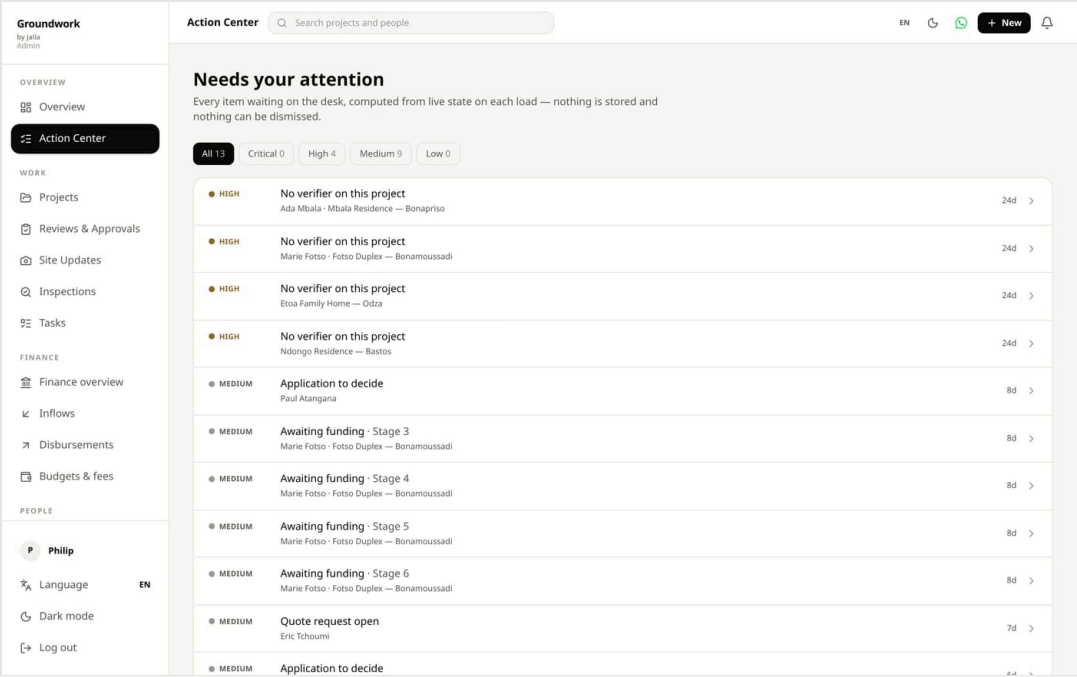


FIG. 3 Action Center. The full triage queue — everything waiting on Groundwork, worst first. The Overview page shows the top five of exactly this list, using exactly the same rules, so the two can never disagree with each other.

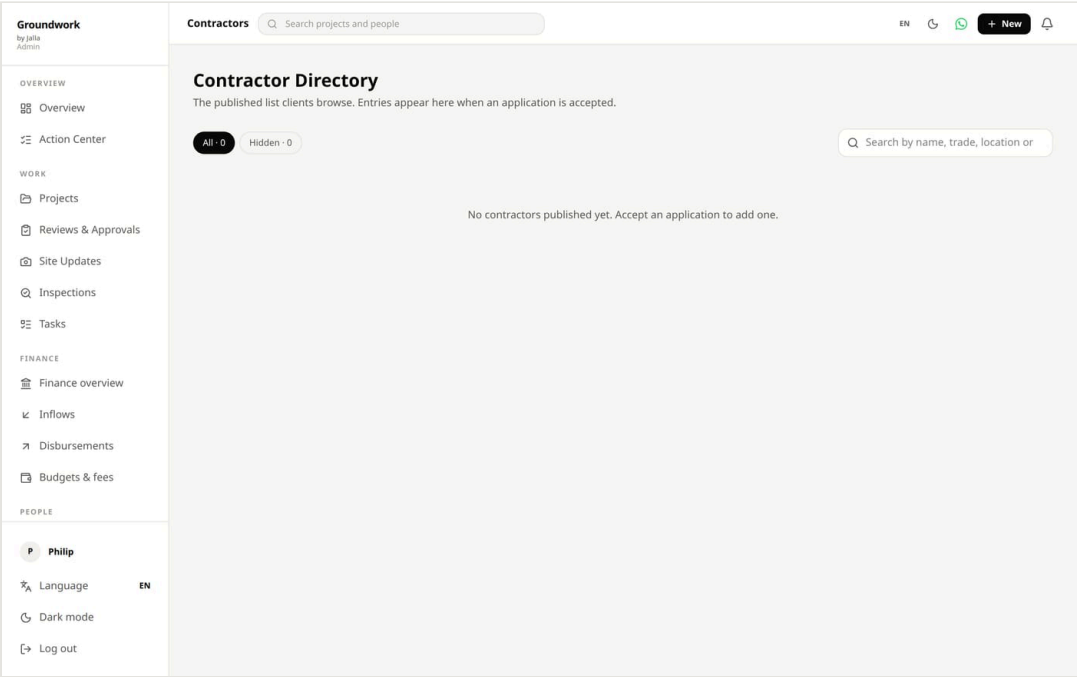


FIG. 4 Contractors. Where you manage the people who build. Payment details are checked from the project's team panel rather than here, because that is the only place the system can be certain which Groundwork account a contractor holds.

The mistake we found, and the repair

This section is the one piece of bad news. I would rather you heard it from me, in full, than discovered it later.

What happened

Changes to the database were applied to the live system *before* they had been reviewed. The review then happened and found real problems — the kind worth catching. Those problems were fixed in our files. But the live system still had the earlier, unreviewed version, and nothing automatically carries a fix across.

So for a period we had two different realities: the code we had reviewed and believed in, and the database that was actually running.

What it broke

LIVE, RIGHT NOW

The application asks the database to save a contractor's bank details using a new field name. The live database still expects the old one. They do not match, so **every attempt by a contractor to save their payment details fails** — both mobile money and bank. It fails cleanly, with nothing half-saved, but it fails.

What was actually wrong in the unreviewed version

Three things, all now corrected. They are worth knowing because each is the kind of error that costs real money rather than embarrassment:

- **A field named for the wrong thing.** We were storing our own internal code for a bank in a field whose name tells the next engineer it holds the payment provider's routing number. Someone would eventually have sent our internal code to a bank as though it were a routing number. Money sent nowhere, discovered days later.
- **A verified account could never be switched off.** A contractor whose bank account closes could not stand it down — and it stayed eligible to receive payments. Found by testing, not by reading.
- **Half-built projects were given a completion date that was invented.** A foundation poured in 2019 was recorded as completed on the day an administrator typed a sentence into a form. That false date would have flowed into every timeline, export and report that reads it.

The repair

A single corrective release, written so that it reaches the correct final state whether it runs on the live system or on a clean one. It was tested in four ways, and I want to call out the fourth, because it is the one that matters for your peace of mind:

TEST	RESULT
Run against a copy of the live system	All twelve checks pass; real dates preserved, nothing invented
Run against an already-correct system	Changes nothing at all — proven by comparing the database before and after, byte for byte

TEST	RESULT
Run twice in a row	Clean; no date re-stamped, no constraint disturbed
Run against deliberately broken data	Stops, and undoes everything it had already done

That last one is the important one. The whole repair now happens as a single operation: it either completes entirely or leaves the system exactly as it found it. There is no outcome where we end up half-repaired and nobody knows which half.

WHAT I NEED

The repair is written, committed and reviewed. **It has not been applied to the live system.** Applying it is a copy-and-paste into the database console and takes a couple of minutes. Until then, contractors cannot save payment details.

What we changed about how we work

Nothing now goes to the live database before review. The sequence is review first, then apply, then confirm against the live system that what we think is there, is there. The confirmation step is new, and it is how this was caught.

Recommendation: open a conversation with Cauridor

We should not be dependent on a single payment partner, and the one we have is currently blocking us. Cauridor is worth a serious look.

Where we actually stand on payments

SwyChr has given us no test environment and no automatic notification when a payment succeeds or fails. We have built everything up to the edge of sending money — approval, records, the exact account to send to, protection against sending twice — but the final outbound step cannot be built against a provider we cannot test against. That is why *Processing* reads zero in Figure 2.

Who Cauridor are

A payments infrastructure company founded in 2022 by Oumar Barry and Abdoulaye Bah, building the rails that connect international money transfer companies to the places money actually has to land in Africa — mobile wallets, bank accounts and cash agents.

SIGNAL	DETAIL
Scale handled	\$500M total payment volume by 2024
Funding	~\$13M total; \$3.5M seed led by Oui Capital; \$2M from Proparco
Who already trusts them	Western Union, MoneyGram and Ria have group-level contracts with them
Last-mile network	25,000+ agents across Guinea, Senegal, Ivory Coast, Sierra Leone and Liberia
Mobile money partners	Orange and MTN — the two operators that matter in Cameroon
Relevant service	They list bulk disbursements — paying many people out, which is exactly our shape

The Proparco investment is worth noting on its own. Proparco is the French development finance institution; they conduct real governance and compliance diligence before investing. That is a meaningful second opinion on a partner who will be holding our clients' money.

Why they fit Groundwork specifically

- **We pay out, we do not collect.** Our need is sending money to contractors on a schedule. Bulk disbursement is a named product for them, not an afterthought.
- **They are built for francophone Central and West Africa**, which is our market rather than a side market they tolerate.
- **They already connect to Orange and MTN** — the rails our contractors actually use.
- **They are an aggregator.** One integration reaches mobile money, banks and cash pickup, instead of three separate relationships.

THE ONE THING THAT DECIDES IT — ASK THIS FIRST

Their own agent network is in Guinea, Senegal, Ivory Coast, Sierra Leone and Liberia. **Cameroon is not on that list.** They describe themselves as covering 36 countries and expanding into Central Africa, and they have offices opening in Mali and Nigeria — but I could not confirm live Cameroon payout coverage from public sources. If they cannot pay out to a Cameroonian MTN or Orange wallet today, nothing else about them matters to us yet.

What I suggest

An introductory call, not a commitment. Five questions decide whether to go further:

- Can you pay out to Cameroon mobile money and bank accounts today? If not, when?
- Is there a test environment we can build against before signing anything?
- Do you notify us automatically when a payout succeeds or fails, or must we poll you?
- What are your fees on a payout in the \$2,000–\$15,000 range, and what is the settlement time?
- What compliance do you need from us, given our clients are mostly diaspora senders?

Questions two and three are the exact ones SwyChr could not answer well, and they are what has us stuck. If Cauridor answers them cleanly, we should take them seriously as either a replacement or a second rail.

Sources: [TechCrunch](#) · [Proparco](#) · [The Paypers](#) · [Cauridor](#). Figures as published; none independently verified by us.

What is deliberately not finished

So that nothing in this report reads as more complete than it is.

AREA	WHERE IT ACTUALLY STANDS	STATE
Sending money	We can approve a payment and record it. The outbound call to a payment provider does not exist, and cannot be built until we have one we can test against.	BLOCKED
The live repair	Written, tested four ways, committed. Not yet applied to the live system.	NEEDS YOU
Verification checkpoints	Design and specification complete, including the three mandatory foundation checkpoints from 13 September. No code written. The current system can only hold one verification per stage, which cannot express "the civil engineer and the electrical engineer must both sign off".	DESIGNED
Stage order corrections	Our foundation stage currently lists backfilling second — before the beams it is supposed to cover. Vanessa's correct order is specified and agreed. Not yet applied, because changing it on projects already under way needs care.	SPECIFIED
Handover certificates	Deliberately untouched. A certificate must mean "everything required was verified", and we cannot yet express what is required at handover.	WAITING
Admin override for testing	From the 30 September stand-up. Not started — it lets an administrator bypass payment gating, so it needs its own design and its own audit trail before it goes anywhere near the system.	NOT STARTED
Mandatory bill of quantities	From the 30 September stand-up. Not started.	NOT STARTED

What happens next, in order

The order matters more than the list. Everything below the line is future architecture; the first item is a live problem.

#	STEP	WAITING ON
1	Apply the repair to the live system, then confirm it landed	A couple of minutes
2	Run the read-only survey of existing projects — how far along they are, what has been paid	Nothing; ready
3	Decide: correct the stage order on existing projects, or leave them as they are	Step 2's answers
4	The Sunday decisions (section 7)	You and Vanessa
5	Correct the foundation order and move finishing work to the finishing stage	Steps 3 and 4
6	Split electrical and plumbing; add the two roofing types	Step 5
7	Pricing changes — removing premium and luxury finishes, roofing costs	Kept separate from everything above, deliberately
8	Build the verification checkpoint system	Steps 4 and 5
9	Handover certificates	Step 8
10	Connect a payment provider and actually send money	Cauridor conversation, or SwyChr improving

WHY PRICING IS KEPT ON ITS OWN LINE

Removing the premium and luxury finish tiers changes what existing clients were quoted. Correcting the foundation order does not. Those two should never travel in the same change, or we will one day correct a construction sequence and silently re-price somebody's house.

Decisions only you and Vanessa can make

Each of these is blocking something specific. None can be answered from the code, and I have deliberately not guessed at any of them.

-
- ☐ **The sand layer**
Our foundation stage has one item combining blocks, polystyrene and sand. The 13 September standard puts a 5 cm sand layer in a different, later step. The same sand cannot be in both places. *Blocks the foundation correction.*

 - ☐ **Existing projects: correct them, or leave them?**
Answer after the survey in step 2. If a project has already paid for and completed foundation work, reshaping its stages is risky; if nothing has moved, it is simple. It may be a different answer per project. *Blocks everything in the stage tree.*

 - ☐ **Must an architect be assigned at project creation?**
On 11 September we settled three mandatory verifiers — structural engineer, electrical engineer, lawyer. But the architect is required at design and at handover. Fourth mandatory role, or assigned when needed? *Blocks verifier setup.*

 - ☐ **At handover, what does "the reports must match" actually mean?**
A civil engineer, an architect and Jalla all report. If they disagree, does that block handover? Who decides? Is Jalla's report a third verification or a review of the other two? *Blocks handover certificates.*

 - ☐ **Who signs off the pre-casting inspection?**
Before the ground floor is cast we inspect plumbing, electrical earthing, sand, plastic and steel — then it is buried. The earthing is electrical work. Is this one civil engineer, or several professionals signing one hold point? *Blocks the checkpoint design.*

 - ☐ **Measured values: numbers, or a signed report?**
Concrete strength appears at four checkpoints. Do we store "28-day: 32.4 MPa" as a number we can search and compare, or accept a signed PDF? *Changes what we build.*

 - ☐ **What is the Exterior Work standard?**
No meeting has defined what is inspected at stage 9, by whom. It is the only stage with no standard at all. *Blocks any stage 9 verification.*

 - ☐ **Meter installation — site preparation or electrical?**
The 13 September record says both. *Small, but it blocks the stage-7 split.*

 - ☐ **Premium and luxury finishes — what about existing clients?**
Removing the tiers was agreed. Clients already quoted on them need a decision: re-price, leave as they are, or convert. *Blocks the pricing work.*

 - ☐ **When is the roof type chosen?**
At project creation, or when the roofing stage arrives? It changes which steps get created. *Blocks the roofing work.*

What I need from you

In priority order.

- **Approve applying the repair** to the live system. Contractors cannot save payment details until this is done.
- **A view on Cauridor.** If you are open to it, I will prepare the five questions as a short brief you can send.
- **Time with Vanessa on the ten decisions** in section 7. Several are quick; the sand layer and the existing-projects question are the two that unblock the most.
- **A decision on the admin override** from the stand-up — whether you want it at all, now that a real payment provider conversation is on the table.

APPENDIX — THE FOUR RELEASES

REFERENCE	WHEN	WHAT IT CONTAINED
994759a	2 Oct, 08:08	Contractor payment details, the main-contractor rule, phone capture, WhatsApp recipients
2ded9b5	2 Oct, 08:27	Safety tests for the above
67fc558	2 Oct, 15:12	Projects joining half-built
d85a9ff	2 Oct, 21:24	The corrective repair, the checkpoint specification, and Vanessa's 18 standards documents

69 files changed, 6,383 lines added. Every release carries automated tests; all pass, and the full check of the codebase is clean.